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PLAYING THE LONG GAME

From reform ambition and fiscal choices to manufacturing, jobs, and investor confidence, the Board of India Today Economists (BITE) offers a detailed analysis of what the Union budget, presented on February 1, promises

Q. What, in your view, are the three biggest thrust areas in Budget 2026?

● **NEELKANTH MISHRA:** The first and most important focus is to stick to the fiscal consolidation roadmap the government outlined last year. The boost to government credibility and rise in predictability are important to bring down the medium- and long-term costs of capital in the economy. Second, prioritising quality of expenditure—capital expenditure is budgeted to grow faster than overall spending. Third, the government laid out the roadmap for growth in services, goods exports (like the customs duty simplification on intermediate goods, and rescinding of several QCOs [Quality Control Orders] earlier; with the US deal done, FTAs now cover 70 per cent of India's exports), and better urban infrastructure (support for City Economic Regions and expansion of municipal bonds).